is to indebt poorer countries so that they can be wedged open for the sake of liberalised trade and investment or simple resource extraction. Expansion of the credit system is also the traditional way to address overproduction of goods, as debt allows these to be mopped up in the present with a promise to extract further surpluses to pay the price in future, in what amounts to a temporal fix. According to Harvey (2003:134), these fixes do not result in crisis *resolution*, but instead they displace capital's overaccumulation.

Indeed, they lead to new contradictions associated with uneven development in the form of 'increasingly fierce international competition as multiple dynamic centres of capital accumulation emerge to compete on the world stage in the face of strong currents of overaccumulation. Since they cannot all succeed in the long run, either the weakest succumb and fall into serious crises of devaluation, or geopolitical confrontations erupt in the form of trade wars, currency wars and even military confrontations.'

The territorially rooted power blocs generated by internal alliances (and conflicts) within national boundaries, or occasionally across boundaries agglomerating to regional scale, are the critical units of analysis when it comes to fending off the devalorisation of overaccumulated capital. By unveiling how these units of analysis are forged within the capital accumulation process, Harvey roots his geopolitical theory and applies it to contemporary imperialism. Sub-imperial states are critical transmission belts according to this theory, in part because the opening up of global markets in both commodities and capital created openings for other states to insert themselves into the global economy. But the sub-imperial elites are rarely patriotic, for they maintain their own personal (and sometimes corporate) accounts in the metropole, leading Harvey (2003:196) to remark,

> The benefits of this system were, however, highly concentrated among a restricted class of multinational CEOs, financiers, and rentiers. Some sort of transnational capitalist class emerged that nevertheless focused on Wall Street and other centres such as London and Frankfurt as secure sites for placements of capital. This class looked, as always, to the United States to protect its asset values and the rights of property and ownership across the globe. While economic power seemed to be highly concentrated within the United States, other territorial concentrations of financial power could and did arise.

The BRICS reflect this new relationship, for as Brazilian president Lula da Silva